

▶ SCENARIO 3

SPLENDID STRIKE

CAUSE

- Suspecting that Pakistan is going to launch its N-weapons or in response to a limited tactical nuke strike, India undertakes missile strikes to destroy Pakistan's N-facilities
- This includes command-and-control centres and underground vaults where it stores its nuclear arsenal

EFFECT

- Since Pakistan's nuclear weapons are spread across many facilities, some of them are likely to survive India's strike
- Pakistan will then use them to strike Indian cities resulting in India carrying out even more nuke strikes



▶ SCENARIO 4

BROKEN ARROW

CAUSE

- In the heat of a limited war, a dual-use supersonic missile is accidentally launched from India and hits a military target in Pakistan's Punjab but doesn't detonate
- For instance in March 2022, a BrahMos test missile was accidentally launched into Pakistani territory but the situation was defused by both sides

EFFECT

- Suspecting that India wants to carry out a nuclear strike, Pakistan retaliates with major nuclear strikes on Indian cities
- If the reverse happens, that is a Pakistan nuclear-tipped missile is accidentally fired into Indian territory and does not detonate, Delhi may presume the worst and launch a devastating strike

than physically destroying large portions of infrastructure." Unless there is clear evidence of Pakistan moving to elevate its nuclear weapons readiness levels, Tellis finds it hard to believe the current crisis would have careened towards a nuclear war.

MEA sources, too, maintain the crisis never acquired nuclear dimensions, and that Pakistan climbed down after the air strikes on its bases as it realised that another two days of war would have forced it into humiliating submission. They say it was Gen. Munir who got in touch with Rubio early that morning and requested him to get India to stand down. Soon after, Rubio called external affairs minister S. Jaishankar, who told him that if Pakistan wanted to cease hostilities, it needed to communicate it via the hotline between their respective director generals of military operations. Maj. Gen. Kashif Abdullah, Pakistan's DGMO, then called his Indian counterpart, Lt Gen. Rajiv Ghai, at 3.35 pm and told him that Pakistan wanted a ceasefire. India agreed and it was mutually decided that it would come into force at 5 pm that day. India denies US intervention in bringing this about.

ON MAY 10, BETWEEN 2.30 AM AND 10.30 AM, THE FATE OF THE SUBCONTINENT HUNG IN BALANCE. HAD A CEASEFIRE NOT BEEN DECLARED, THE WAR COULD HAVE GONE NUCLEAR IN 24-48 HOURS

This explanation flies against Trump's assertion that he had averted a potential nuclear conflict. Rubio, too, had several rounds of discussions with the key players—Jaishankar,